

You should be able to add a ‘rider’ to your existing policy on the policy renewal date. A rider is an add-on at a very low cost to a basic policy. Riders look attractive, but I recommend that you buy a stand-alone accident policy from a general insurer. This cover is likely to be more comprehensive and will not lapse if you discontinue your basic policy for any reason.

A personal accident policy adds another layer of security to your by-now robust medical insurance portfolio. This kind of policy gives you a lump sum if you meet with an accident that leaves you temporarily or permanently disabled. A personal accident plan has four covers: death, permanent disability, permanent partial disability and temporary total disability.

For death or permanent disability, you mostly get the entire sum assured. For permanent partial disability, the policy pays a part of the sum assured, and for temporary total disability, it pays a weekly compensation, usually up to 104 weeks.

How much insurance you buy depends on how insecure you feel about your health and the future. An old wise uncle, now deceased, once told me that we all need to decide what level of safety makes us feel safe. Do you need a helmet or a seat belt on the road or do you need an armoured car? The answer will depend on who you are and what danger you perceive, and what you are able to afford.



I know, you're tired of reading. And I'm tired of putting down all there is to buying a medical plan. It is tough. There are too many moving parts. You can use the Mint SecureNow Medclaim Rating to shortlist some products, but the best solution will be to work with a good financial planner to buy your medical plan. Use the information here to see if the planner knows more than you or not. If you don't hear the words pre-existing, sub-limits, claims and waiting periods, you know that you need to keep searching.

You can make out from the tone of this part of the book how deeply I distrust insurance firms. This comes from years of getting complaints from people who have been trapped and cheated. It comes from decoding products and finding a problem of intent in lots of them.